

STAGE FIFTEEN • BUSINESS & ORGANIZATIONAL ACUMEN

FIRSTS

DISCUSSION PROMPTS

Open-ended questions to seed group conversation beyond the worksheets

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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FIRSTS • Discussion Prompts

Stage Fifteen • Business & Organizational Acumen

PURPOSE

Individual worksheets answer “what did your analysis conclude?” These prompts answer a different question: “what's your real, lived experience of trying to understand and analyze an organization?” They're open-ended and grounded in real work or internship experience, meant to seed conversation beyond a simple share-out of worksheet answers.

Use these during share-out portions, when a session finishes its planned agenda with time to spare, or when a group's energy needs a genuine, specific prompt rather than “any volunteers?” They're organized by session, four prompts each.

Because this stage draws heavily on real workplace experience, some participants (especially those without much prior work history) may have less to draw on for certain prompts.

Encourage reframing toward school, internships, or even a part-time job — the underlying dynamics (unclear goals, a broken process, a surprising decision) show up in nearly any organizational context.

Prompts by Session

SESSION 1

Understanding How Organizations Work

"Have you ever made a decision or recommendation at work that seemed reasonable, but didn't actually fit how the organization makes money? What happened?"

"What's a department at your organization whose actual function still feels like a mystery to you?"

"Has anyone ever shown you a real P&L or budget document for the first time? What surprised you about it?"

"What's a metric your organization tracks that you suspect might not be the right one? Why?"

SESSION 2

Analyzing the Business

"Has a piece of market or competitive research ever genuinely changed your mind about something you'd assumed internally?"

"What's the hardest part of building a business case, from your own experience: the numbers, the recommendation, or something else?"

"Think of a process you've been part of that had a real bottleneck. Was it ever actually fixed? What happened?"

"Have you ever pitched a recommendation and gotten pushback that revealed a gap in your own analysis? What did you learn?"

SESSION 3

Strategic & Reflective Business Thinking

"Have you ever discovered that something you were working on had genuinely no connection to your team's actual stated goals?"

"What's a real organizational decision that made more sense once you understood the full reasoning behind it?"

"Has your organization gone through a real change recently? What made it feel well-managed, or poorly managed?"

"Looking back across this whole stage, which part of business acumen feels most natural to you, and which feels like real, ongoing work?"